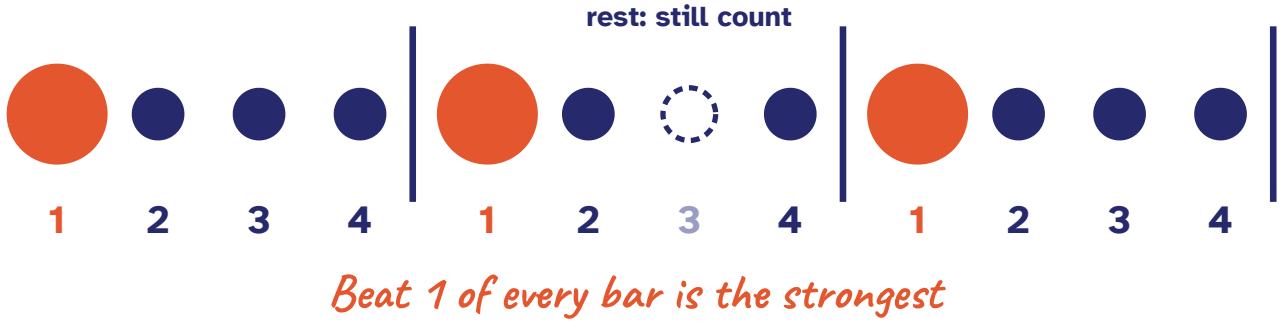
PART II · TIME · 1

# Pulse, tempo and the bar

Put your hand on your heart: that steady beat is a **pulse**, and almost every piece has one. Its speed is the **tempo**. Beats travel in groups called **bars**, and beat 1 is the strongest.

**THE SECRET**

**The beat never stops, not even in a rest. Feel it before you play.**




*Beat 1 of every bar is the strongest*

## Tempo

Tempo is measured in beats per minute. A **metronome mark** at the top of the music shows it: ♩ **= 60** means 60 crotchet beats a minute, one beat a second. ♩ **= 120** is twice as fast. Tempo words such as *Andante* and *Allegro* come with Expression, later in the book.

## Strong and weak beats

| BEATS | PATTERN | FEELS LIKE |
|---|---|---|
| 2 | **Strong** weak | a march |
| 3 | **Strong** weak weak | a waltz |
| 4 | **Strong** weak **medium** weak | most songs |

## Bars and bar lines

| SIGN | NAME | MEANING |
|---|---|---|
| | bar line | divides the music into bars |
| | double bar line | marks the end of a section, or a change of key, time signature or tempo |
| | final bar line | marks the end of the piece |
| | repeat signs | play the passage between them again; if there is no start sign, go back to the beginning |

PART II · TIME · 1 · CONTINUED

## The beat in tunes you know

| TUNE | BEATS IN A BAR | PATTERN |
|---|---|---|
| Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star | 4 | **Strong** weak **medium** weak |
| Happy Birthday | 3 | **Strong** weak weak |
| The Blue Danube (a waltz) | 3 | **Strong** weak weak |
| Radetzky March | 2 | **Strong** weak |

## Counting

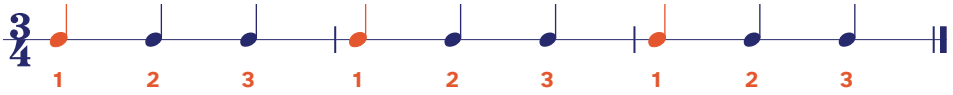



Three bars of 3/4. Every beat is counted, even inside a long note: the red number is where you play, the grey numbers are the beats you hold.

Count aloud at one speed, a little louder on beat 1. With a metronome, start slower than you think and speed up only when the passage is steady.

EXAMPLE 1

### Is this a march or a waltz?




1. **Tap a steady beat** as you clap or listen.
2. **Find the strong one:** the red beats feel heavier.
3. **Count the gap** between strong beats: 1 2 3, 1 2 3.

Groups of three: a **waltz**, in 3/4. Groups of two would be a march.

EXAMPLE 2

### Feel the beat before you play

♩ = 96




1. **Read the mark:** ♩ = 96, 96 crotchet beats a minute.
2. **Listen first:** set the metronome and let one full bar go by, counting “1 2 3” in your head.
3. **Step in** on the next beat 1, the way you step onto a moving escalator.

The first note lands **on the beat**, not a guess.

PART II · TIME · 1 · CONTINUED

GAME

### How many beats in a bar?

1 2 3 4

The big dot is the strong beat. Count the beats in each bar: 2, 3 or 4?

Answer: 1 three (a waltz) · 2 four · 3 two (a march) · 4 three, twice.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS




### Hand on your heart. Tap the beat.

Say “1 2 3 4” with your taps, 1 a little louder. Keep going for ten seconds without slowing down.

HOW TO

### Find the beat of a new piece

1. **Read the time signature:** how many beats in each bar.
2. **Tap the beat** on your knee before you play, counting one bar aloud.
3. **Start slower** than the marked speed, and keep it steady to the end.

YOU KNOW THIS

### Radetzky March (Johann Strauss I)




At the New Year concert the audience claps along on **every beat**. That steady clap is the pulse; the orchestra’s tune moves freely over it.

**Try it.** Put on any march and clap only the beat, not the tune.

THINK OF IT The beat is the stage and the notes are the actors: the stage is there before anyone walks on. So step in the way you step onto an escalator or take a plate off a sushi train: watch it move for a bar, then join in.

TRAP

- × Speeding up in easy bars and slowing in hard ones: the pulse never changes.
- × Counting only the notes you play: the beat goes on through long notes and rests.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 55 · Tempo words: Expression (later)

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · Pulse · Online: Metronome